From Chatbot to Copilot: Bank AI That Explains, Proposes, Acts

upvance

Area: Technology WEAK SIGNAL

Banking-app AI is moving from answering questions to explaining a customer's money, proposing a next step and, in pilots, carrying it out. Willingness runs ahead of use: 69% of Americans would let a bank AI do a task (2026), but 1% have used one that acts (2025).

FORCES

- Models can now plan multi-step tasks
- Payment networks build rails for agents
- Customers already ask general AI about money
- The money conversation moves outside the app

VALUES

- Human override over full autonomy
- Double-checking over trusting the answer
- A known actor over an anonymous agent
- Duty of care over 'just a tool'

PHASE

Emerging

Only 1% of Americans have used AI that acts for them in finance (2025); every acting feature still needs explicit confirmation.

EXAMPLES

- Robinhood (US, 2026): Cortex AI tools used by nearly 1 million customers; trades need explicit confirmation.
- Public, US brokerage (Nov 2025): almost half of earlier AI-assistant chats led to a trade within 24 hours.
- Santander and Visa (Mar 2026): AI agents completed payments in a pilot across five Latin American markets.
- Bankinter (Jul 2026): one of four Spanish banks in Visa's live pilot of agent-initiated payments.
- AMF France (2025): 11% use AI before investing, against 42% who ask a bank or adviser.
- EY (23 countries, 2026): 49% of 18,152 people used AI for savings or investment decisions.

INNOVATORS

- Starling Bank, UK's first agentic assistant
- Vladimir Tenev moved Robinhood to AI-initiated trades
- Visa spreads agent payments to banks
- European Banking Authority sets explainability limits

IMPACT

- ▲ A first-time investor gets an ETF explained, a budget-sized proposal and a pre-filled order, all in one conversation.
- ▼ The copilot gets it wrong, the customer buys and loses money, and public AI tools offer no complaint route.
- More delegation may lift conversion but cuts against the control customers ask for; 55% of Americans want more human input.
- Customers learn to hand logins to anything called an agent; 19% of US adults say one has already asked.

RO/EU lens: Banca Transilvania and Visa piloted Romania's first agent-initiated payment (Jul 2026, one payment); 62% of Romanian retail investors are open to AI investment picks (eToro, 2026).

Why it matters: The 'explain' step is shipping; the 'act' step is where trust, control and the first 'buy' are decided.

Sources: 21 sources, short research, in the Research document